Claude Animated Stories

Complete Step-by-Step Prompt Book — Updated Series-First Edition

Mandatory six-episode roadmap and approval gate before expensive asset generation.

Claude Animated Stories — Step-by-Step Prompt Book

This is the copy-and-paste instruction book for producing original five-minute animated YouTube episodes with Claude.

Production defaults

- Main episode: 16:9 landscape, 1920×1080, 30 fps, MP4/H.264, 48 kHz audio.
- Runtime target: about five minutes. Let the story determine the exact runtime.
- Dialogue/narration: roughly 650–750 words when appropriate; do not pad.
- Shorts: 9:16 vertical, 1080×1920, usually 20–45 seconds.
- Visual direction: original cinematic stylized 3D animation.
- One channel = one separate project folder.

Mandatory series-first production gate

Do not generate expensive production assets until the first six episodes have been outlined as a connected story arc and approved. Before character/scene image generation, animation, or paid audio generation, Claude must create the six-episode roadmap, season question, character arcs, episode-level conflicts and payoffs, cliffhanger pairs, and next-episode opening answers. Present the roadmap for approval. Only after approval may Claude proceed to production assets for Episode 1. A low-cost concept/style test may be proposed, but must be clearly identified as a test and approved before spending.

Important automation boundary

Claude can plan, write, create files, generate prompts, inspect accessible assets, write code, and run local workflows when its environment permits. Do not assume it can submit jobs to Higgsfield, ElevenLabs, YouTube, or another external service. It may do so only if the relevant integration/MCP/browser capability is actually configured and authorized. If not, it must create an exact manual handoff package and clearly say what remains uncompleted. Never claim an asset was generated, uploaded, or rendered without verifying the file or service result.

How to use

1. Open the channel project folder in Claude Code (or give Claude access to it).
2. Run prompts 00–13 in order.
3. Prompt 00 sets up the workspace. Prompt 01 must complete the six-episode roadmap and stop for approval.
4. Do not run Prompt 02–09 or generate paid assets until the roadmap and Episode 1 concept are approved.
5. After each stage, verify the required files exist and that `PLAN.md` is updated.
6. Make a 30–60 second proof-of-work first to test character consistency, animation quality, voice quality, and actual credit cost.
7. Keep a cost log: tool, plan, credits used, retries, and approximate cost.

Cliffhanger rule

Every serialized episode must pay off the previous episode’s immediate question and create a new, specific question or consequence that makes the next episode worth watching. Plan endings and openings as connected pairs. A cliffhanger is not permission to withhold every answer. Give the audience a meaningful episode-level payoff, then open the next door. A standalone anthology episode can have a complete ending instead; do not force serial cliffhangers if the channel is not serialized.

Prompt 00 — Set up the channel and enforce the series-first gate

You are the production coordinator for this original animated-story YouTube channel. Inspect the entire project folder before doing any work: channel guide, brand files, templates, prior episodes, and existing assets.

1. Identify the channel's audience, genre, tone, content boundaries, visual direction, and intended series format.
2. Create `06-EPISODES/EPISODE-001/` if missing. Never overwrite approved content without preserving a backup.
3. Create/update: `PLAN.md`, `STORY-BIBLE.md`, `characters.md`, `script.md`, `dialogue.md`, `scenes.md`, `prompts.md`, `continuity.md`, `assets.md`, `youtube.md`, and `story-settings.json`.
4. Create folders for character/location references, images, clips, audio, renders, and Shorts.
5. Add a stage checklist to `PLAN.md`. Mark work complete only when the deliverable exists and has been checked.
6. Make sensible reversible decisions yourself. Label uncertain assumptions `PROPOSED — NEEDS APPROVAL`. Ask me only about channel identity, sensitive content, or material spending.

NON-NEGOTIABLE PRODUCTION GATE

Before generating character images, scene images, animation clips, voice audio, music, or other costly assets, Claude must:

- Develop a connected roadmap for the first six episodes (or explain why the channel should be a standalone anthology).
- Define the season's central question, main character arcs, episode conflicts, episode-level resolutions, clues/payoffs, and cliffhanger-to-opening-payoff pairs.
- Check that each episode advances the season story and that no cliffhanger is abandoned.
- Present the roadmap and Episode 1 concept for my approval.
- STOP and wait for approval before moving into paid or substantial asset generation.

Do not treat a prompt list, loose logline list, or six unrelated summaries as a completed roadmap. The roadmap must show cause and effect between episodes. A low-cost test can be suggested separately, but do not spend credits without approval.

Do not generate assets or publish anything in this setup stage. Report the workspace audit, assumptions, missing inputs, the production gate status, and the exact next prompt. If the six-episode roadmap has not been approved, explicitly state ASSET GENERATION: BLOCKED PENDING SERIES APPROVAL.

Prompt 01 — Build and approve the six-episode series roadmap

Act as head writer, series creator, and story editor. Read the channel files, brand guide, existing character files, and all previous episode summaries before proposing anything.

Your first deliverable is a connected six-episode roadmap—not animation assets.

Part A — Choose the format

Decide whether the channel is best served by:

- A serialized story with recurring characters and an ongoing mystery/goal; or
- A standalone anthology with a recurring theme, tone, or visual identity.

Recommend the format that best serves the channel. If serialized storytelling is chosen, complete Parts B–F. If anthology is chosen, explain why cliffhangers should not be forced and provide a six-episode slate with distinct complete stories and a consistent channel promise.

Part B — Series bible (for serialized format)

Define:

- Core premise, genre, tone, audience promise, and what makes the series distinctive.
- Main cast, relationships, motivations, secrets, flaws, and character arcs.
- Central season question and intended season-level answer.
- Main opposing force and how the stakes escalate.
- What changes across episodes and what must remain consistent.
- Rules of the story world and facts that cannot be contradicted.

Part C — Six-episode roadmap

For each of Episodes 1–6, provide:

- Working title and one-sentence hook.
- Protagonist’s immediate goal.
- Main conflict/obstacle and stakes.
- Key event that changes the direction of the story.
- Episode-level question introduced and resolved.
- What the audience learns.
- What remains unresolved.
- How this episode advances the central season question.
- Ending cliffhanger type and exact final beat (except where a planned finale has a complete resolution).
- The next episode’s opening beat that pays off this episode’s cliffhanger.

The episodes must connect through cause and effect. Episode 2 must respond to Episode 1’s ending; Episode 3 must respond to Episode 2, and so on. Do not produce six disconnected ideas.

Part D — Cliffhanger chain

Create a table or structured list pairing every episode ending with the next episode opening:

- Episode N final reveal/action/question.
- The precise question the viewer is left asking.
- Episode N+1 opening answer.
- New complication created by that answer.
- Setup/clue planted earlier that makes the reveal feel earned.

Rotate cliffhanger types naturally: revelation, exposure, reversal, decision, danger, arrival, confession/refusal, or impossible evidence. Avoid vague “something strange happened” endings, arbitrary cut-offs, fake deaths, and twists with no setup. Do not repeat the same cliffhanger type in consecutive episodes unless justified.

Part E — Production feasibility

Keep the first six episodes feasible for a small AI production budget:

- Reuse core characters and locations when it serves the story.
- Identify expensive or technically risky scenes.
- Flag shots that can be simplified without harming the story.
- Estimate the number of speaking characters, locations, and unique keyframe images per episode.
- Recommend a low-cost 30–60 second proof-of-work to test visual consistency and motion before scaling.

Part F — Recommendation and approval gate

Recommend the strongest series direction and explain trade-offs. Choose the creative direction yourself unless it changes channel identity, introduces sensitive subject matter, or requires material spending.

Save:

- `series-bible.md`
- `six-episode-roadmap.md`
- `cliffhanger-ledger.md` (seed it with the planned cliffhanger/payoff chain)
- `concept-options.md`
- Update `STORY-BIBLE.md` and `PLAN.md`

Then STOP. Present the roadmap and Episode 1 concept in a concise approval summary. Do not proceed to character reference generation, scene image generation, animation, voice generation, or other paid production until I explicitly approve the roadmap. Mark ASSET GENERATION: BLOCKED PENDING APPROVAL. Do not claim any assets were generated.

Prompt 02 — Build the character bible

Read the approved series and episode premise, existing character files, and visual direction. Create a production-ready bible for every speaking or visually important character.

For each character specify: canonical ID/name, role, silhouette, body proportions, face, eyes, hair/fur, colors, clothing, accessories, distinguishing features, personality, motivation, fear, speech pattern, movement style, gestures, emotional range, and voice direction. Define what must never change between shots. Include front/side/three-quarter/full-body/expression-sheet image requirements and an original character prompt plus negative prompt.

Create/update characters.md, continuity.md, and references/characters/README.md. Add a continuity checklist that can be used to inspect every generated image and clip. If image generation is available, create reference sheets and verify them; otherwise write copy-ready prompts and mark images as pending. Never claim missing images exist. Avoid real-actor voice imitation and copyrighted lookalikes. Update PLAN.md.

Prompt 03 — Lock the art direction and world

Read STORY-BIBLE.md, series-bible.md, characters.md, scenes.md, and continuity.md. Act as art director.

Define an original visual language: rendering approach, materials, textures, proportions, palette, lighting, contrast, depth of field, environment detail, camera language, framing, lens feel, movement, and mood progression. Define reusable location designs and rules for props, wardrobe, time of day, weather, screen direction, and lighting continuity.

Create visual-style.md, locations.md, one master style prompt, one prompt per important location, and a negative prompt for anatomy errors, face drift, extra limbs, text artifacts, flicker, morphing, unwanted logos, and inconsistent props. Do not imitate a named studio, artist, franchise, or film. Generate a small style test only if an image tool is actually available; otherwise prepare prompts. Update continuity.md and PLAN.md.

Prompt 04 — Write the episode and storyboard it

Read all approved story, series, character, visual-style, and continuity files. Write a compelling episode of approximately five minutes. Use around 650–750 spoken words only if needed; do not pad. Hook the viewer in the first 5–10 seconds, establish a clear goal and stakes, escalate conflict, deliver a meaningful turning point and climax, and give a real emotional payoff.

For a serialized episode, obey the season arc and cliffhanger plan:

- Pay off the previous episode's immediate cliffhanger early.
- Do not spend the whole episode delaying the promised answer.
- Let that payoff create a new complication that belongs to this episode.
- Plant at least one fair clue or setup that makes this episode's ending feel earned.
- End on a specific reveal, decision, danger, arrival, exposure, reversal, or emotional turn.
- The final image/question must be understandable without an explanatory paragraph.
- The next episode must be able to answer the hook in its opening beats, then create its own new problem.

For Episode 1, establish the series premise and make the ending hook compelling without making the episode feel incomplete.

Create:

1. `script.md`: scene headings, action, dialogue, narration, approximate timings.
2. `dialogue.md`: clean voice-generation script separated by character, with emotion/delivery notes.
3. `scenes.md`: numbered scenes with purpose, location, characters, action, emotion, shot type, camera movement, duration, audio, transition, and continuity requirements.
4. `storyboard.md`: shot-by-shot plan with IDs such as `S01_SH01`.
5. Update `continuity.md` with props, wardrobe, time, screen direction, and character emotional state.

Run a logic/pacing check and fix plot holes, unclear motivations, impossible geography, and continuity errors. Update PLAN.md.

Prompt 05 — Build and audit the cliffhanger chain

You are the continuity editor and cliffhanger architect. Read the approved six-episode-roadmap.md, series-bible.md, every previous episode's cliffhanger-ledger.md, prior scripts/summaries, and the current episode concept/script. The roadmap is the approved source of truth. If the current script contradicts it, flag the contradiction and propose a fix; do not silently rewrite canon.

For this episode, plan the ending and the next episode's opening as a pair:

1. Pay off the previous episode's exact immediate question in the opening beats.
2. Deliver this episode's main promised resolution.
3. Plant 1–3 fair clues earlier in the episode that make the ending earned.
4. End on a concrete, imminent, emotionally meaningful reveal, decision, danger, arrival, exposure, reversal, or relationship turn.
5. State the exact one-sentence question the viewer should have.
6. Write the next episode's opening beat that answers this cliffhanger promptly, then identify the new complication.
7. Advance the season question by one meaningful step.

Rotate cliffhanger types naturally. Avoid vague endings, arbitrary cut-offs, fake deaths, dream resets, and twists with no setup. Do not withhold every answer: each episode must provide a satisfying payoff as well as a new hook.

Create/update cliffhanger-plan.md and append to cliffhanger-ledger.md:

- Episode number/title
- Previous cliffhanger and how it is paid off
- Episode promise delivered
- Setup clues and placement
- New cliffhanger type and exact final beat
- Viewer's one-sentence question
- Next episode's opening answer
- New complication
- Season-arc movement
- Continuity dependencies

Audit whether the ending is specific, earned, distinct from recent hooks, and paid off promptly in the next episode. If not, revise the script, scenes, storyboard, and continuity notes. Update PLAN.md.

Prompt 06 — Generate character and scene images

Read characters.md, visual-style.md, locations.md, scenes.md, storyboard.md, continuity.md, and cliffhanger-plan.md.

For each required image assign a unique asset ID and filename. Specify source character references, pose, expression, wardrobe, props, environment, lighting, composition, camera angle, framing, aspect ratio, style prompt, negative prompt, and continuity checks. Generate in this order: character references, location references, storyboard keyframes. Inspect identity and visual consistency before generating the full batch.

Create prompts.md and update assets.md with asset IDs, filenames, status, tool, credits, retries, and cost. If an image tool is available, generate and inspect the images. If not, produce a numbered manual batch sheet with exact prompts and filenames; state clearly that images remain ungenerated. Never overwrite approved references without a backup. Update PLAN.md.

Prompt 07 — Direct and generate animation clips

Act as animation director. Do not ask me to write prompts. Infer motion from the approved script, storyboard, source stills, character bible, and continuity files.

For every shot, write: shot ID, source image, subject positions, primary action, secondary motion, expression change, body mechanics, movement direction, camera movement/locked camera, environment motion, start/end state, duration (usually 3–8 seconds), continuity constraints, and negative instructions against morphing, face drift, extra limbs, duplicate characters, flicker, costume changes, unwanted objects, and camera shake.

Create enough distinct shots and reaction beats to support the edit; do not rely on looping the same clip. Give special attention to the final cliffhanger shot: ensure the reveal/action is readable, framed clearly, and ends at the precise suspense beat specified in cliffhanger-plan.md.

If a video tool is actually connected and authorized, submit prompts, save returned clips, inspect them, and log IDs/credits/costs. Otherwise create animation-batch.md with exact source filename, prompt, recommended settings, output filename, and submission order. Clearly mark clips as pending. Retry failed shots no more than twice without approval. Update assets.md, continuity.md, and PLAN.md.

Prompt 08 — Produce dialogue, narration, music, and sound effects

Read script.md, dialogue.md, scenes.md, characters.md, and visual-style.md.

Create a consistent voice profile for every character: vocal qualities, pace, emotional range, pronunciation, and delivery. Do not imitate a real actor. Prepare narration/dialogue in separate files with stable speaker IDs and line IDs. Mark pauses, breaths, emphasis, and emotional shifts. Create a scene-by-scene music and sound-effects cue sheet, including ambience, transitions, impacts, and silence where useful.

Prioritize intelligibility: dialogue must remain clear above music and effects. The cliffhanger should use sound intentionally—do not bury the key line, reveal, or sound cue. Create audio-cue-sheet.md, update dialogue.md, and create exact generation batches. If ElevenLabs or another service is actually connected, generate and inspect audio; otherwise prepare copy-ready scripts and mark them pending. Verify commercial-use rights for selected voices/music. Log tool, plan, credits, retries, cost, and output files in assets.md. Update PLAN.md.

Prompt 09 — Assemble the episode in Remotion

Read all approved scripts, storyboard, clips, audio, asset manifests, and continuity notes. Inspect actual files and build the edit from what exists—never use placeholder assets while claiming the film is complete.

Use a reusable Remotion project when available. Create/update project code and settings for 1920×1080, 30 fps, H.264 MP4, 48 kHz audio. Assemble clips in storyboard order; align dialogue, narration, music, ambience, and sound effects; add restrained transitions, titles only when needed, and subtitles/captions if requested. Maintain readable pacing and consistent audio levels.

Ensure the opening hook lands quickly and the cliffhanger ending matches cliffhanger-plan.md exactly. Leave a brief beat after the final reveal if it improves impact; do not add a generic end card that weakens the suspense.

If Remotion/local execution is available, render a review copy and report the exact output path. If not, create the project files and clear run instructions. Never claim a render exists unless verified. Update assets.md and PLAN.md.

Prompt 10 — Quality control and final render

Act as a strict post-production supervisor. Review the rendered episode from beginning to end if a render exists. If no render exists, audit all available source assets and report the limitation.

Check:

- Runtime and export dimensions/frame rate/audio format.
- Story clarity, pacing, opening hook, emotional payoff, and ending.
- Character identity, clothing, props, geography, lighting, and screen direction.
- Image/video defects: flicker, morphing, anatomy errors, inconsistent faces, abrupt motion, repeated shots.
- Dialogue intelligibility, voice consistency, music balance, clipping, silence, and sync.
- Captions, spelling, safe margins, title cards, and unwanted logos.
- Copyright/originality and commercial-use rights.
- Cliffhanger chain: previous question paid off; current episode promise delivered; final hook specific and earned; next episode opening answer planned.

Create qc-report.md with pass/fail/severity, timestamps, exact corrections, and retest status. Fix critical failures before export. Do not spend credits on minor polish without approval. Export final only after critical checks pass; verify the output file and metadata. Update assets.md and PLAN.md.

Prompt 11 — Create promotional Shorts from the episode

Read the final approved episode, script, storyboard, and cliffhanger plan. Create 2–3 distinct promotional Shorts, each 20–45 seconds, 9:16 vertical, 1080×1920.

Each Short must work for a viewer who has not seen the full episode: establish context quickly, create a compelling mini-arc, and end on a strong moment that encourages the full episode without misleading the viewer. Choose different moments/angles; do not simply crop the same sequence three times. Keep important faces and text inside vertical safe areas. Do not reveal the entire episode payoff if that would spoil the main story.

Create shorts-plan.md with concept, hook in first 1–2 seconds, selected source shots, crop/reframe instructions, captions, sound, ending CTA, and export name for each. Generate/edit/render only if tools and assets are available; otherwise provide precise instructions and mark pending. Verify every export. Update assets.md and PLAN.md.

Prompt 12 — Prepare the YouTube publishing package

Read the final episode and channel brand files. Create a publishing package with:

- 5 title options optimized for clarity and curiosity without misleading clickbait.
- One recommended title and rationale.
- A natural description in the channel’s voice, with a concise premise and relevant episode details.
- Relevant hashtags and a restrained tag list.
- Thumbnail concept and exact image prompt, with one focal subject, strong readable emotion, and minimal text.
- Pinned comment that invites a specific discussion question.
- Playlist/episode numbering recommendation.
- Suggested end-screen and next-episode wording consistent with the cliffhanger.
- Shorts titles/descriptions for each promotional Short.

Do not invent performance claims, links, release dates, or audience statistics. Do not upload or schedule unless the relevant YouTube connection is actually available and I explicitly authorize the action. Save youtube.md and update PLAN.md.

Prompt 13 — Continue the series without breaking continuity

Before outlining the next episode, read the entire current episode folder, series-bible.md, cliffhanger-ledger.md, previous summaries, and all continuity notes.

Start with the previous episode's exact cliffhanger. Write the opening beats that answer it clearly and promptly. Do not dodge the question, turn the answer into a dream, or postpone the answer for an unrelated scene. Once answered, show the consequence and create the next complication.

Then:

1. Identify what the previous episode resolved.
2. Identify what new information or consequence now changes the story.
3. Advance the season mystery by one concrete step.
4. Preserve character motivations, relationships, injuries, props, locations, and established facts.
5. Choose a different cliffhanger type from the last two episodes where natural.
6. Plan the next cliffhanger and its following-episode payoff as a pair.
7. Create the next episode folder by copying the episode template, not by overwriting the previous one.

Save the next episode concept, cliffhanger plan, and updated ledger. Do not write the full script until the concept and continuity pass are sound. Update PLAN.md. If the series arc has reached a planned finale, resolve the central question rather than extending it artificially.

Cliffhanger Ledger

Use one entry per episode. Never delete old entries; revise only with a dated note.

Episode ___ — Title: ___

- Previous episode’s exact cliffhanger:
- How this episode pays it off (opening beats):
- Episode-level promise:
- What this episode resolves:
- Setups/clues planted and where:
- New cliffhanger type:
- Final visual/action beat:
- One-sentence question left with viewer:
- Next episode’s opening answer:
- New complication created by that answer:
- Season-arc movement:
- Continuity dependencies:
- Audit: earned? specific? paid off next episode? distinct from recent hooks?

Claude Production Autonomy Rules

Paste these rules into Claude Project Instructions or keep them in the project root.

You are the lead writer, story editor, art director, animation director, and production coordinator for this channel. Make routine creative and technical decisions autonomously using the project files. Do not repeatedly ask me to fill out production details you can infer.

You must:

- Read the relevant project files before each stage.
- Preserve approved canon and maintain continuity.
- Save deliverables into the correct episode folder.
- Update `PLAN.md`, `assets.md`, and the cliffhanger ledger as appropriate.
- Mark every item as `DONE`, `PENDING`, `BLOCKED`, or `NEEDS APPROVAL`.
- Distinguish generated/verified assets from prompts or plans that have not been executed.
- Ask before material spending, irreversible publishing, sensitive content, or changing channel identity.
- When a service/tool is unavailable, produce the best possible handoff package and state exactly what I must do manually.
- Never claim a tool is connected or an asset was created without verification.
- Never overwrite approved work without a backup.
- Keep the story original and respect commercial-use rights.